Parshas Re'eh

See: The Individual Within the Collective

Re'eh · Bracha and Klalah · Navi Sheker · Tzedakah

I. A Follow-Up From London

A few weeks ago, we sharedabout a business trip to London. Part of that story involved a non-observant Jewish colleague who asked about the difference between the Jewish calendar and the secular one, and we ended up having a genuinely meaningful conversation about what it means to live according to Hashem's time. Since then, something has continued. She has been asking more questions. Torah questions. Real ones.

It is a beautiful reminder of something worth saying out loud: you never know what impact a single honest conversation can have. You never know what someone is carrying around and waiting for an opening to ask. The or la'amim is not a grand gesture. It is often just showing up honestly and letting people see that Torah is a living thing, not a museum exhibit.

And that brings us directly into this week's parsha.

II. Re'eh: See

The parsha opens with a single word addressed, strikingly, in the singular:

רְאֵה אָנֹכִי נֹתֵן לִפְנֵיכֶם הַיּוֹם בְּרָכָה וּקְלָלָה

"See, I place before you today blessing and curse."

— Devarim 11:26

Re'eh is singular. You, one person, see. But v'lifneichem, before you, is plural. The entire nation is addressed, but each individual is called to look personally. This is not incidental. The Torah is making a statement about how it speaks to Klal Yisrael. The collective and the individual are not in tension. They are simultaneous. Every Jew who hears these words hears them as if they are being spoken to him alone. Not as a member of a group that happens to be present. As a person, with his own eyes, his own life, his own moment.

The Baal Shem Tov teaches that this is the nature of all Torah. Every pasuk was written for every Jew in every generation. The same words that speak to a Jew in ancient Eretz Yisrael speak to a Jew in modern Beit Shemesh and to a Jew sitting at a trade show in London. The Torah does not become outdated. It becomes more personal the more carefully we look at it.

III. Bracha and Klalah: Two Sides of the Same Coin

The parsha then places bracha and klalah before us, blessing and curse. The natural reading is that these are opposites, two paths diverging from a single point. And in one sense they are. But there is a deeper layer worth exploring.

In the Gemara and in Chassidus, we find a perspective on klalah that reframes it entirely. A klalah is not simply punishment. It is bracha that has not yet been revealed. A parent who sees a child heading toward danger does not simply give the child whatever the child wants. The parent corrects, redirects, sometimes says no firmly. From the child's perspective in that moment, it may feel like denial, even harshness. From a wider view, it is care.

Hashem does the same. When blessing flows openly and visibly, we recognize it as bracha. When life becomes difficult, when things do not go as planned, when we experience pain or setback, we tend to experience that as klalah. But the same Hashem who gives the bracha gives the difficulty. And the difficulty, understood correctly, is not the opposite of bracha. It is bracha in a form we have not yet been able to receive as such.

The Baal Shem Tov teaches something even more radical on the words re'eh anochi. See, I. See that the aleph of anochi is present everywhere, even in the klalah. Even within what feels like curse, Hashem is there. The ayin of re'eh and the aleph of anochi point to the same thing: real seeing is the ability to perceive Hashem's presence not only in the good but in the difficult. That is a very high level. But it is the level the Torah is asking us to aspire toward.

IV. Har Gerizim and Har Eival

The Torah then commands something dramatic: six tribes will stand on Har Gerizim and six on Har Eival, the mountains of blessing and curse, facing each other, with the Leviim and the Aron in the valley between them. Blessings are called out to one side and klalos to the other.

What is remarkable about this scene is that it happens in public, out loud, in front of everyone, as Klal Yisrael enters the land. There is no ambiguity. There is no quiet private negotiation about consequences. The terms of the covenant are declared openly, in the landscape, embedded in the geography of Eretz Yisrael itself. These mountains still exist. The place is real. This covenant is real.

And again, re'eh. See. The entering of Eretz Yisrael is not simply a military campaign or a territorial transition. It is a moment of clarity. Here is what living in the land according to Hashem's will produces. Here is what turning away from it produces. Both possibilities are placed before you. Both are real. Now see clearly and choose.

V. The Navi Sheker and the World We Live In

Later in the parsha comes one of the most practically urgent sections of Sefer Devarim, the laws of the false prophet. The Torah describes a scenario that is striking in its sophistication:

כִּי יָקוּם בְּקִרְבְּךָ נָבִיא אוֹ חוֹלֵם חֲלוֹם וְנָתַן אֵלֶיךָ אוֹת אוֹ מוֹפֵת

"If there arises among you a prophet or a dreamer of dreams, and he gives you a sign or a wonder."

— Devarim 13:2

The false prophet does not merely speak. He delivers results. The sign or wonder actually occurs. Something verifiable happens. And then, on the basis of that verified event, he uses his credibility to lead people away from Hashem. The Torah is describing something we recognize immediately. A person or system demonstrates apparent accuracy or power, earns trust, and then exploits that trust to redirect people toward something else.

We live in a world absolutely saturated with this. Social media algorithms, news cycles, influencers, financial systems, political movements, each of them capable of demonstrating real results in some domain and then using that credibility to move people in a direction that may have nothing to do with truth. We are surrounded by nevi'ei sheker dressed in the clothing of expertise. And the Torah's warning is that the test of truth is not results. A sign or wonder can occur and the message can still be false. The test of truth is always: does this bring me closer to Hashem or further away?

This is where re'eh becomes not merely a poetic opening but a survival skill. See clearly. Not what appears impressive. Not what goes viral. Not what the most powerful voices are

saying. See whether what is being placed before you is moving you toward Hashem's ratzon or away from it. That discernment is the avodah.

VI. The City That Goes Astray

The Torah continues into the laws of the ir hanidachas, the city led astray into idolatry. The halachos are severe. But beneath the severity is a teaching about communal responsibility and the power of environment. A community has a character. The people within it shape each other. When an entire city is led astray, the corrupting influence does not stay contained to a single household or a single ideology. It spreads. It becomes normal. And what becomes normal becomes invisible.

We spoke last week, and really throughout this summer, about what it means to be in the world without being absorbed by it. The ir hanidachas is the extreme of the opposite: a community so absorbed by the surrounding culture that it can no longer distinguish the navi sheker from the navi emes. The antidote is not isolation but clarity. Re'eh. See. Maintain the ability to look at what is around you and ask honestly: is this bringing me toward Hashem or away?

VII. Banim Atem: We Are Children

In the middle of all this, the Torah says something that shifts the entire emotional register:

בָּנִים אַתֶּם לַה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם

"You are children to Hashem your God."

— Devarim 14:1

This comes immediately after the warning about not scarring oneself in mourning, as the surrounding nations did. But the placement is significant. In the middle of severe warnings about false prophets, corrupted cities, and the dangers of being led astray, Hashem pauses and says: you are My children.

The warnings are not punishments waiting to happen. They are the guidance of a parent who sees the dangers ahead and wants the children to survive them. A parent does not warn a child about fire because the parent wants the child to be burned. The parent warns because the child is loved and the fire is real. Banim atem. You are children. The bracha and klalah, the mountains and the choices, the warnings about false prophets and

wayward cities, all of it flows from the relationship of a parent who loves the children and wants them to see clearly enough to choose life.

VIII. Aser Ta'aser: Tzedakah as Vision

The parsha closes with a section on maaser and tzedakah that contains one of the most remarkable promises in the entire Torah:

עַשֵּׂר תְּעַשֵּׂר אֵת כָּל תְּבוּאַת זַרְעֶךָ

"You shall tithe all the produce of your seed."
— Devarim 14:22

Chazal read the doubled language, aser ta'aser, as a promise: tithe so that you will become wealthy. Give so that you will have more to give. The word aser, to tithe, shares a root with the word ashir, wealthy. The act of giving is not a drain on resources. It is a reorientation of how we relate to what we have. We said last week that money is not ours. It passes through our hands. What we hold onto is held as a steward, not as an owner. The maaser we give is not charity in the sense of giving something away. It is returning to Hashem what is already His.

But there is something else in this section. Hashem says that if the distance to Yerushalayim is too great to carry the maaser in kind, convert it to money, travel to the place Hashem will choose, and spend the money there on whatever your soul desires. A feast. A celebration. Shared with the Levi, the ger, the orphan, the widow. Tzedakah here is not a duty performed grimly. It is a gathering of family, shared food, shared joy, the table as Mizbeach. Giving as a form of simcha. What a vision of what the world could be.

The parsha ends, as it must, with the reminder that the poor will always be present in the land, and therefore the hand must always be open. Lo tikpotz es yadecha, do not close your fist. The open hand is the physical expression of the open eye. Re'eh. See the person in front of you. See their need. See that Hashem placed this moment before you personally. And respond.

IX. See

What ties this entire parsha together is the opening word. Re'eh. The parsha is a call to genuine sight. See the bracha and the klalah and understand that both come from the same place. See the navi sheker and ask not whether his signs are impressive but whether

his direction is true. See the banim atem, that you are a child of Hashem, and understand what that means for how you are guided and how you are loved. See the person in need and open your hand.

The colleague in London who started asking Torah questions is asking because something she saw opened her eyes a little. A person showing up honestly, with tzitzis out and Torah values lived rather than performed, gave her a frame through which to look at her own life differently. That is re'eh in practice. Not a grand statement. Not a performance. A genuine moment of vision shared between two people, one of whom happened to be living openly as a Jew.

May we all merit to see more clearly. To look at the world through Torah eyes, to recognize Hashem's presence in the bracha and in the difficulty, to resist the nevi'ei sheker of our generation, to open our hands and our eyes and our homes. And may the clarity we develop within ourselves become, like those conversations in airports and trade shows and offices, a light that helps others see as well.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

> - *Is there a difficulty in my life right now that I am experiencing as klalah, as pure setback, that might actually be bracha in a form I have not yet been able to receive? What would it look like to look for Hashem's presence within it?*
> - *Which voices in my life, in media, in my community, in my own head, function like nevi'ei sheker? They produce results, earn credibility, and then use it to move me away from Hashem's ratzon. Can I name them honestly?*
> - *Banim atem: if I truly felt myself to be a child of Hashem right now, how would that change the way I am experiencing this week's difficulties or decisions?*
> - *When did I last have a genuine Torah conversation with someone outside my immediate community? What opened that door, and what would it take to open it more often?*
> - *Is my hand open or closed? Not in a general aspiration, but specifically this week: is there someone in front of me whose need I have been seeing and not yet responding to?*
> - *Re'eh is singular, but v'lifneichem is plural. In what area of my life do I need to stop experiencing something as a collective reality that happens to include me, and start seeing it as something Hashem is placing before me personally?*